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Section Title(S)

Introduction • The Use of Bena Kin Terms

Swahili is not a recent language among the Bena. At least thirty-five years ago it was in common use and at least some of the Swahili kin terms noted here were in use.³ The early German literature hints at the presence of Swahili among the Bena in the mid-1890's but it is not possible to determine whether the language was confined to the relatively few men who had visited the coast or otherwise had extensive direct contact with Swahili-speakers or that it was more widespread. It is also not possible to determine whether or not Swahili kin terms were being used during this period of first European contact.

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This paper has three objectives: to discuss the ways in which kin terms are used by the Bena; to present a complete list of these terms in both Kibena and Swahili; and to examine some of the differences between the groupings of kin resulting from differences between the two terminologies.

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The Use of Bena Kin Terms

All Bena kin terms are used both in reference and address (with the exception of some descriptive words used in conjunction with other terms as, for example, '*big* father' used to refer to father's older brother who is called simply 'father'). Because of this, they are constantly heard in conversation. The terms are very widely applied and a person will always be addressed by a kin term if any sort of consanguineal or affinal tie can be asserted to exist. The Bena do not remember exact genealogical connections beyond the third ascending generation as a rule, but if two individuals can agree on some sort

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of a blood or marriage bond between them they will often use kin terms for one another appropriate to their relative generations (or ages when generational position is unclear) and to the type of link they believe exists. The terms used in address under such circumstances can be the same as those used for kin or affines to whom ties can be traced with precision, but for those with whom the exact nature of the relationship cannot be established the term will be qualified in reference by the phrase 'of the family' (Sw. *wa ukoo*; Kib. *munyalukolo*), so, for example, one's own mother's own brother is *yaya* (Sw. *mjomba*) and someone thought to stand in the same sort of genealogical position might be called by the same term in address but in reference this would be clarified and explained by speaking of him as *yaya munyalukolo* (Sw. *mjomba wa ukoo*).

Alternatively, a person thought to be a relative but to whom exact relationship cannot be traced can be addressed and referred to as *lukolovangu* (Sw. *ndugu*). This term means simply 'relative' or 'kinsman' and implies no particular type of relationship other than that of general friendliness and some warmth. Specific terms are used ⁴³ rather than the generic one when more particular types of behaviour are felt to be appropriate even when there is no reason to think the actual relationship is of the sort to which the term is proper when exact genealogical ties can be traced. Thus, a person with whom one is on good terms and who is thought to be a relative who is about one's own age and general status will be addressed by cross-cousin or sibling in-law terms implying freedom of expression, lack of restraint concerning joking and matters of bodily functions (i.e. sex and elimination can be freely and frankly discussed). A somewhat older person will be addressed and referred to by elder sibling or parental terms implying respect and restraint and a much older putative relative will be the object of grandparental terms again implying comradeship and freedom from restraint.

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³ A. and G. Culwick: *Ubena of the Rivers*. London: Allen and Unwin, 1935, p. 189.

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